Why are Christian video games deemed preachy?

Case Studies Into the Formal Elements of Christian Entertainment Software and How They Affect Player Engagement.

Domenico Agius

Supervised by Prof. Stefano Gualeni

Institute of Digital Games
University of Malta

March, 2026

A dissertation submitted in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the degree of M.Sc. in Digital Games.

Copyright ©2026 University of Malta

WWW.UM.EDU.MT

First edition, Saturday 7th March, 2026

To John Doe

Some more descriptive text.

Acknowledgements

These are the acknowledgements. Hello, here is some text without a meaning. This text should show what a printed text will look like at this place. If you read this text, you will get no information. Really? Is there no information? Is there a difference between this text and some nonsense like "Huardest gefburn"? Kjift – not at all! A blind text like this gives you information about the selected font, how the letters are written and an impression of the look. This text should contain all letters of the alphabet and it should be written in of the original language. There is no need for special content, but the length of words should match the language.

Abstract

Hello, here is some text without a meaning. This text should show what a printed text will look like at this place. If you read this text, you will get no information. Really? Is there no information? Is there a difference between this text and some nonsense like "Huardest gefburn"? Kjift – not at all! A blind text like this gives you information about the selected font, how the letters are written and an impression of the look. This text should contain all letters of the alphabet and it should be written in of the original language. There is no need for special content, but the length of words should match the language. Hello, here is some text without a meaning. This text should show what a printed text will look like at this place. If you read this text, you will get no information. Really? Is there no information? Is there a difference between this text and some nonsense like "Huardest gefburn"? Kjift – not at all! A blind text like this gives you information about the selected font, how the letters are written and an impression of the look. This text should contain all letters of the alphabet and it should be written in of the original language. There is no need for special content, but the length of words should match the language. Hello, here is some text without a meaning. This text should show what a printed text will look like at this place. If you read this text, you will get no information. Really? Is there no information? Is there a difference between this text and some nonsense like "Huardest gefburn"? Kjift – not at all! A blind text like this gives you information about the selected font, how the letters are written and an impression of the look. This text should contain all letters of the alphabet and it should be written in of the original language. There is no need for special content, but the length of words should match the language. Hello, here is some text without a meaning. This text should show what a printed text will look like at this place. If you read this text, you will get no information. Really? Is there no information? Is there a difference between this text and some nonsense like "Huardest gefburn"? Kjift – not at all! A blind text like this gives you information about the selected font, how the letters are written and an impression of the look. This text should contain all letters of the alphabet and it should be written in of the original language. There is no need for special content, but the length of words should match the language. Hello, here is some text without a meaning. This text should show what a printed text will look like at this place. If you read this text, you will get no information. Really? Is there no information? Is there a difference between this text and some nonsense like "Huardest gefburn"? Kjift – not at all! A blind text like this gives you information about the selected font, how the letters are written and an impression of the look. This text should contain all letters of the alphabet and it should be written in of the original language. There is no need for special content, but the length of words should match the language.

Contents

List of Abbreviations **x**

1 Introduction **1**
1.1 Motivation 1
1.2 Aims and Objectives 1
1.3 Our Approach 1
1.4 Document Structure 2

2 Background & Literature Overview **3**
2.1 What are Christian Video Games? 3
2.2 Related Work 4
2.3 Summary 4

3 Materials & Methods **5**
3.1 Summary 5

4 Results & Discussion **6**
4.1 Summary 6

5 Conclusions **7**
5.1 Revisiting the Aims and Objectives 7
5.2 Critique and Limitations 7
5.3 Future Work 8
5.4 Final Remarks 8

Appendix A Media Content **9**

Appendix B Installation Instructions **10**

Appendix C User Manual **11**

References **12**
Ludography 12

List of Figures

List of Tables

List of Abbreviations

1

Introduction

1.1 | Motivation

1.2 | Aims and Objectives

Hello, here is some text without a meaning. This text should show what a printed text will look like at this place. If you read this text, you will get no information. Really? Is there no information? Is there a difference between this text and some nonsense like "Huardest gefburn"? Kjift – not at all! A blind text like this gives you information about the selected font, how the letters are written and an impression of the look. This text should contain all letters of the alphabet and it should be written in of the original language. There is no need for special content, but the length of words should match the language.

1.3 | Our Approach

Hello, here is some text without a meaning. This text should show what a printed text will look like at this place. If you read this text, you will get no information. Really? Is there no information? Is there a difference between this text and some nonsense like "Huardest gefburn"? Kjift – not at all! A blind text like this gives you information about the selected font, how the letters are written and an impression of the look. This text should contain all letters of the alphabet and it should be written in of the original language. There is no need for special content, but the length of words should match the language.

1.4 | Document Structure

Hello, here is some text without a meaning. This text should show what a printed text will look like at this place. If you read this text, you will get no information. Really? Is there no information? Is there a difference between this text and some nonsense like "Huardest gefburn"? Kjift – not at all! A blind text like this gives you information about the selected font, how the letters are written and an impression of the look. This text should contain all letters of the alphabet and it should be written in of the original language. There is no need for special content, but the length of words should match the language.

2

Background & Literature Overview

2.1 | What are Christian Video Games?

In an interview, games scholar Kevin Schut states that currently, there is no consensus on what defines a Christian game (Faith Forms, 2024, 8:38). This becomes apparent when one examines online discussion around the topic. For example, one of the factors that Moon Channel (2023) considers when determining if a video game is Christian is that it must promote Christian morals. Meanwhile, Hartgrove (2022) considers *Hypnospace Outlaw* (2019) a Christian game primarily because its creator, Jay Tholen, identifies as a Christian[1]. Within the same interview, Schut also seems to imply that the definition is subject to change, given that the use of the label is undergoing constant cultural negotiation (08:50, 24:26). Therefore, before conducting my study, I needed to establish a static working definition of "Christian video games".

Earlier work by Schut (2013) gives us a good starting point for such a definition. Based on a series of interviews with seventeen Christians working in the game industry, he outlined four definitions of "Christian Games". Explicitly Christian Games "feature Bible stories or passages, very clear presentation of the gospel message, and stories that very openly have a Christian worldview". As an example, Schut raises *Big Bible Town* (2010), a video game which aims to teach children about Bible stories. Meanwhile, Allegorical Christian Games "have stories that are not necessarily openly Christian but have Christian themes or messages underneath them" (p. 137). Interviewees mentioned no instances of such games, but they cited the Narnia series by C.S. Lewis as an example of this style.

Interviewees also raised what Schut terms as Evangelical Christian video games, which "focus on sharing the gospel with people who aren't Christians". (pp. 137–138).

[1] Although Hartgrove does discuss the game's content somewhat, he does not deem explicit ideological content as necessary.

However, this is only a hypothetical definition since Schut could not cite an examples. Lastly, Christian-friendly games, such as Bejeweled and Words With Friends, are "clean and safe, without significant violence, adult sexuality, swearing, anti-Christian worldviews, and other things that Christians might find offensive or disturbing" (p. 137).

Schut's work also gives valuable insight into how the term "Christian Games" is used. For example, he notes that most of the interviewees commonly defined "Christian Games" as either Explicitly Christian Games or Allegorically Christian games. However, only few of them considered Christian-friendly games part of the genre. Based on these observations I could have based my definition on the most common uses of the term. However, there was one issue which made me hesitant to do so — the ambiguous use of the term "Christian".

While the distinction between "Christian" and "non-Christian" outlooks or morals may seem trivial, there have been disagreements in the past. For example, Gonzalez (2014) talks about *The War In Heaven* (1999), a first-person shooter which has been criticised for allowing players to play as demons. She points out an anonymous review in which the reviewer argues that the game does not teach the Bible in the right context (p. 209). Nevertheless, the developers defended this inclusion, stating that "[their] design is in accordance with Biblical teachings" (p. 204).

Subsequent work by Schut (2026) acknowledges the subjective application of this term, and clarifies his use of the term "Christian".

2.2 | Related Work

2.3 | Summary

3

Materials & Methods

This section should include a recipe of what you did (explain what you have done so if someone wants to reproduce the experiment, they can). Should also include a description of statistical methods used (if any).[1]

Hello, here is some text without a meaning. This text should show what a printed text will look like at this place. If you read this text, you will get no information. Really? Is there no information? Is there a difference between this text and some nonsense like "Huardest gefburn"? Kjift – not at all! A blind text like this gives you information about the selected font, how the letters are written and an impression of the look. This text should contain all letters of the alphabet and it should be written in of the original language. There is no need for special content, but the length of words should match the language.

3.1 | Summary

Hello, here is some text without a meaning. This text should show what a printed text will look like at this place. If you read this text, you will get no information. Really? Is there no information? Is there a difference between this text and some nonsense like "Huardest gefburn"? Kjift – not at all! A blind text like this gives you information about the selected font, how the letters are written and an impression of the look. This text should contain all letters of the alphabet and it should be written in of the original language. There is no need for special content, but the length of words should match the language.

[1]For more information see: `http://rc.rcjournal.com/content/49/10/1229.short`. Last Accessed: 27th November, 2024.

4

Results & Discussion

Should include a reiteration of the experiments, and their outcome. Together with a description (discussion). Preamble should include a reminder of the aims and objectives together with a list of experiments to achieve these. Should include many charts and other visualization with appropriate descriptions.[1]

Hello, here is some text without a meaning. This text should show what a printed text will look like at this place. If you read this text, you will get no information. Really? Is there no information? Is there a difference between this text and some nonsense like "Huardest gefburn"? Kjift – not at all! A blind text like this gives you information about the selected font, how the letters are written and an impression of the look. This text should contain all letters of the alphabet and it should be written in of the original language. There is no need for special content, but the length of words should match the language.

4.1 | Summary

[1] Another footnote example.

5

Conclusions

This section should have a summary of the whole project. The original aims and objective and whether these have been met should be discussed. It should include a section with a critique and a list of limitations of your proposed solutions. Future work should be described, and this should not be marginal or silly (e.g. add machine learning models). It is always good to end on a positive note (i.e. 'Final Remarks').

5.1 | Revisiting the Aims and Objectives

Hello, here is some text without a meaning. This text should show what a printed text will look like at this place. If you read this text, you will get no information. Really? Is there no information? Is there a difference between this text and some nonsense like "Huardest gefburn"? Kjift – not at all! A blind text like this gives you information about the selected font, how the letters are written and an impression of the look. This text should contain all letters of the alphabet and it should be written in of the original language. There is no need for special content, but the length of words should match the language.

5.2 | Critique and Limitations

Hello, here is some text without a meaning. This text should show what a printed text will look like at this place. If you read this text, you will get no information. Really? Is there no information? Is there a difference between this text and some nonsense like "Huardest gefburn"? Kjift – not at all! A blind text like this gives you information about the selected font, how the letters are written and an impression of the look. This text should contain all letters of the alphabet and it should be written in of the original language. There is no need for special content, but the length of words should match the language.

5.3 | Future Work

Hello, here is some text without a meaning. This text should show what a printed text will look like at this place. If you read this text, you will get no information. Really? Is there no information? Is there a difference between this text and some nonsense like "Huardest gefburn"? Kjift – not at all! A blind text like this gives you information about the selected font, how the letters are written and an impression of the look. This text should contain all letters of the alphabet and it should be written in of the original language. There is no need for special content, but the length of words should match the language.

5.4 | Final Remarks

Hello, here is some text without a meaning. This text should show what a printed text will look like at this place. If you read this text, you will get no information. Really? Is there no information? Is there a difference between this text and some nonsense like "Huardest gefburn"? Kjift – not at all! A blind text like this gives you information about the selected font, how the letters are written and an impression of the look. This text should contain all letters of the alphabet and it should be written in of the original language. There is no need for special content, but the length of words should match the language.

A

Media Content

If the dissertation has a DVD or pendrive attached to it, you will need a section which explains what is on the media (structure, files, data, etc.). This could be a table with filename and description.

Hello, here is some text without a meaning. This text should show what a printed text will look like at this place. If you read this text, you will get no information. Really? Is there no information? Is there a difference between this text and some nonsense like "Huardest gefburn"? Kjift – not at all! A blind text like this gives you information about the selected font, how the letters are written and an impression of the look. This text should contain all letters of the alphabet and it should be written in of the original language. There is no need for special content, but the length of words should match the language.

B

Installation Instructions

Hello, here is some text without a meaning. This text should show what a printed text will look like at this place. If you read this text, you will get no information. Really? Is there no information? Is there a difference between this text and some nonsense like "Huardest gefburn"? Kjift – not at all! A blind text like this gives you information about the selected font, how the letters are written and an impression of the look. This text should contain all letters of the alphabet and it should be written in of the original language. There is no need for special content, but the length of words should match the language.

C

User Manual

Hello, here is some text without a meaning. This text should show what a printed text will look like at this place. If you read this text, you will get no information. Really? Is there no information? Is there a difference between this text and some nonsense like "Huardest gefburn"? Kjift – not at all! A blind text like this gives you information about the selected font, how the letters are written and an impression of the look. This text should contain all letters of the alphabet and it should be written in of the original language. There is no need for special content, but the length of words should match the language.

References

Faith Forms. (2024). *The problem with christian games* [Video]. Retrieved April 16, 2025, from https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mZTJ0NCIPyw

Gonzalez, V. (2014). *Born-again digital: Exploring Evangelical video game worlds* [Doctoral dissertation]. University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill.

Hartgrove, W. (2022). *Why are Christian video games so bad?* [Medium]. Retrieved March 5, 2025, from https://medium.com/@mediocratesgames/why-are-christian-video-games-so-bad-ec1ef47afa0b

Moon Channel. (2023). Why aren't there any good Christian games? Retrieved May 15, 2024, from https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=COiNrIM9KVE

Schut, K. (2013). Making a different world: Christians building video games [Kindle edition]. In *Of games and God: A Christian exploration of video games* (pp. 127–148). Baker Publishing Group.

Schut, K. (2026). Swords of the spirit, praise music, and scripture: Investigating the unusual world of Christian video games. In M. Wysocki, B. Brey, G. Voorhees, & J. Call (Eds.), *Epistemic genres: New formations of play* (1st ed., pp. 296–313, Vol. 11). Bloomsbury Publishing.

Ludography

Crashable Studios (2015). *Alum*. (Crashable Studios: Windows)
Konami (1986). *Castlevania*. (Konami: Nintendo Entertainment System)
Molleindustria (2010). *Run, Jesus Run!*. (Molleindustria: Online)
n0g0d (2000). *Crucify-me! Jesus*. (n0g0d: Online)

Tendershoot, Michael Lasch, ThatWhichIs Media (2019). *Hypnospace Outlaw*. (No More Robots: Windows)
Third Day Games (2010). *Big Bible Town*. (Third Day Games: Windows)
Vox Day (1999). *The War in Heaven*. (ValuSoft: Windows)